Key question
Why did British rule lead to an Arab rebellion in Palestine?

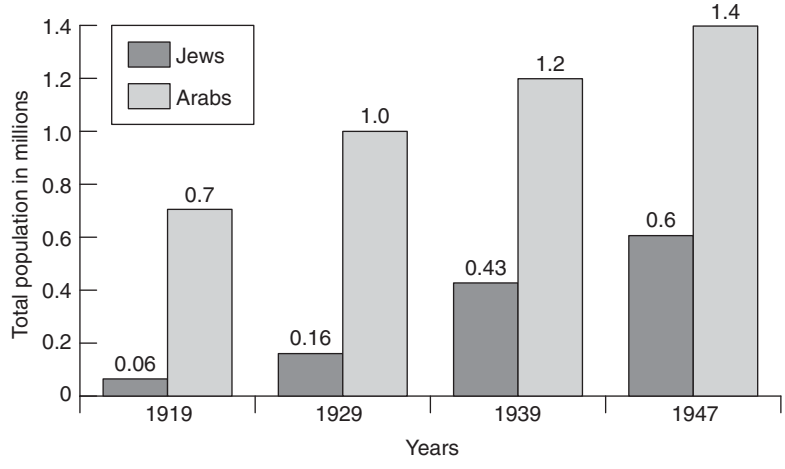
Nazi anti-Semitism and Jewish immigration

Key dates
Hitler came to power in Germany: 1933

Arab Rebellion: 1936–9

Similar outbreaks of violence, although not so widespread, continued in the early 1930s, especially after 1933. In that year Adolf Hitler came to power in Germany and Nazi anti-Semitism drove many Jews abroad. Thousands fled to Palestine and by 1939 there were nearly 450,000 Jews in the country. Tension remained high and British government reports all came to the same conclusion: the Arabs were afraid of losing their country as more and more of them became 'landless and discontented'.

The British therefore planned to restrict immigration and land sales. This caused uproar among the Jews in Europe and the USA as well as in Palestine, so the plan was put aside. The British were in an impossible position: if they allowed unrestricted immigration, Arab fears and violence would increase. But if they stopped or controlled immigration, the world would accuse them of inhumanity, of not caring for the Jews who were being persecuted by the Nazis.



Jewish and Arab populations in Palestine, 1919–47.

The Arab Rebellion 1936–9

In April 1936 widespread fighting broke out as armed Arab bands attacked Jewish settlements. Within a month, over 20 Jews had been killed. By mid-summer, Palestine was caught up in a civil war that was to last for three years and cost hundreds of lives. The British responded harshly. They hanged several Arab leaders and destroyed houses suspected of containing Arab terrorists or arms. They also helped to train and organise the Jewish Defence Force, the **Haganah**.

Key term
Haganah
The Jewish Defence Force, which was set up in the 1920s and was later to form the basis of the Israeli army.

Orde Wingate was a British officer who trained Jewish squads to attack Arab villages during the rebellion. He was an effective military leader, but also a very cruel one.

> Wingate went up to the four Arab prisoners. He said in Arabic, 'You have arms in the village. Where have you hidden them?' The Arabs shook their heads. Wingate reached down and took sand from the